R2, Where are You?

By Tig Notaro

INTRODUCTION

Tig Notaro was a little-known comedian from Mississippi until a catalogue of tragedies changed her life – in 4 months. She was diagnosed with a potentially fatal condition called C. Diff. That's where bacteria attacks the intestinal lining. Her mother, after a fall at home, lapsed into a coma and died. And her yearly mammogram revealed invasive cancer in both breasts. Her stand-up comedy took on a new tone that launched her to stardom. In R2, Where are You? Tig Notaro remembers her mother's death and the impact it had on her and her stepfather.

(Pg 134-139) When I was little, I made a mess of my room, like any other child. The difference between me and other kids was, the person overseeing my cleanup was my stepfather, Rick. Rick was an attorney and in the military. He was very stoic, removed, emotionless.

I used to joke and say that he was kind of like C-3PO, but with less emotion. And then it dawned on me recently that that joke actually doesn't make any sense, because C-3PO is very emotional.

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He's like, "R2, where are you?!' You know? My stepfather was never in a panic looking for me the way C-3PO was looking for R2.

So cleaning up my room -- I was given an allotted time, and then Rick would come in, and whatever was out of place, he would put in a large trash bag. And then he'd lock it in the trunk of the car. Then I had to do chores to earn money to buy my toys back.

I know, it sounds harsh - because it is.

But to be fair, they were priced fairly. I could buy an entire Millennium Falcon, windup Evel Knievel, and stuffed monkey for like a nickel each. Totally reasonable.

But Rick, he was hard-core.

Meanwhile, my mother was very emotional and passionate and affectionate. She was wild and funny. She was originally from southern Mississippi and was raised in a very conservative house.

She was always wanting to make sure that I knew that the most important thing in life was to be happy. And she just supported anything I did. Anything I did

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was so cool, and I always looked adorable, and everything was just great, you know?

Even down to my dropping out of high school. My mother would brag to people.

She was like, "Yeah, Tig dropped out, you know? She's doing her own thing."

My own thing? I had nothing going on. I was working at a pizza parlor or selling po' boys. That was me "doing my own thing."

But then I found stand-up comedy, and I immediately had focus in my life. I was so passionate and excited about it.

And my mother, she didn't care if I was in some dingy club in Middle America or on TV, she just thought I was cool. As long as I was happy, she was happy.

Rick told me that my career was a waste of my time and a waste of my intelligence, and he thought that I should be a doctor or a lawyer. He suggested that I quit comedy and go to business school. Even just a couple of years ago, when my career was going fine, and I was making good money.

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I said, "So you're telling me if I quit comedy and go to business school, something I'm ***not at all interested in***, and end up working in a cubicle in an office somewhere, with the life sucked out of me, you would support that?"

He said, "Absolutely."

It was like, wow, okay.

Although my mother was very supportive of me, we certainly had our differences and problems. I remember one time a decade ago being on the phone fighting, and when the argument wasn't going anywhere, when I was midsentence, she just abruptly handed the phone to Rick.

He said, "Tig, your mother doesn't want to talk to you," and he just hung up on me.

I kept calling back, no answer. It was so frustrating and stifling. This March my phone rang, and the word PARENTS popped up on my caller ID. I was like, ***Oh, this is probably my mother calling to wish me a happy birthday.*** Because a couple of days before was my birthday, and I had missed her call.

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But when I answered the phone, it was Rick. And Rick has only called me like two times in my entire life.

One was to tell me . . . I have no idea what that was about.

But the second time was this time, and he was calling to tell me that my mother had fallen and hit her head and was not going to make it.

I immediately pictured her lying in a hospital, just barely hanging on, saying, "Call Tig. Tell her to come to Texas to say good-bye."

I said, "Can I talk to my mother? Put her on the phone."

And he said, "No. You can't ever talk to her again."

My mother had suffered massive brain hemorrhaging, with zero chance of recovery. It was really so intense to process that-that I would never be able to talk to her again.

I've reflected a lot recently about that phone call over a decade ago when we were arguing, and I've thought about how I know my mother would give anything in the world to be able to come back to talk to me.

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I always think that if somebody could be like, "Okay, you can come back, but you have to come back to that phone call where you're fighting with Tig," there would be zero fighting. It would be only ***I love you's and I'm sorry's*** from both of us.

After my mother's funeral, we left Mississippi, our hometown where she was buried, and we were driving back to Texas. My brother and my uncle were in one car, and Rick and I were in the other.

He said, "Tig, I want to talk to you about something."

And I was like, ***Oh, great. What could this be? I'm not in the mood.***

He said, "I wanted to talk to you about that time that you said that I hurt your feelings. The time when I told you you should go to business school."

I said, "Oh, yeah. That hurt my feelings, but what really hurt my feelings was telling me my career was a waste of my time and a waste of my intelligence. That was hurtful."

And he started to cry. The robot started to cry.

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He said, "I was wrong, and I wanted to apologize for that. I never understood you as a child. I didn't get you at all, and I tried to project onto you my life and my route, and I expected you to take that exact same route. And I'm realizing that it's not the child's responsibility to teach the parent who they are. It's the parent's responsibility to learn who the child is, and I didn't do that, and I'm sorry."

And I'm crying, too. I said, "So are you saying that if I said I was going to quit comedy and go to business school, you wouldn't support that anymore?"

He said, "Absolutely not. Comedy is the only thing in the world that you should be doing."

And I was like, ***Oh, my gosh. I didn't even realize that I needed that so desperately, to hear that.*** And the only thing that really bums me out is that my mother wasn't there to hear him tell me that.

This Thanksgiving I went to Texas, and we actually spent it with Rick's side of the family. I needed to get away and just be by myself, and I decided to drive to my mother and Rick's house. When I pulled up into the

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driveway, I had a full-on breakdown, just sobbing in the driveway, because I was like, ***Oh, my gosh, my mother is not in that house.***

And of course I knew that, but it just really hit me in the driveway. Then I walked inside, and the house still smelled like her. And everything was just so quiet. I was looking around, and still photos that were framed just seemed so still - moments in time caught and gone forever. All the photos were still placed where my mother had placed them over the years.

I started opening drawers, because I wanted to just see something of my mother's. She would write little notes to herself, like, ***"Dentist 2:00 p.m. tomorrow."*** And she was an artist, and she would sketch me perfectly on a napkin when I was just sitting around, and so I was looking for those kinds of things in the drawers, and there wasn't anything in there.

I went to open a closet, and there's nothing there. I found nothing in any drawers or closets, and I started going around the house, just running around, trying to find something. Then I was in this panic and crying even

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harder.

Rick had gutted the house like he had when I was a child with a trash bag.

Everything was gone, and I was like, ***That is it. I am done with this person.*** I couldn't believe I had fallen for that conversation, and I was so ready to write him off immediately. I was done.

I called him on my cell phone, and he said, "Hello, Tig, how are you doing?"

I said, "Not good. Not good. All of my mother's things are gone, and so are my childhood things."

He said, "Hold on a minute. Go into my bedroom. Go into my closet," and he started directing me.

I was like, "Yeah?"

He said, "Look at the top shelf."

And up there he had placed my mother's things, and my childhood things. I opened the box. She was a dancer, too, and there were her ballet slippers and photos.

I was like, "You're lucky."

And although before March, when the word

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PARENTS popped up on my caller ID, it represented my mother and Rick. Now when the word PARENTS pops up on my caller ID, it's only Rick.

We have very different cleanup techniques, but I'm learning to get used to that.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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